

 RELOCATION GUIDE

Darwin

Garramilla

A relocation guide for healthcare professionals and their families. The work, the neighbourhoods, the money and the weekends in Darwin.

Sunset markets. Medicine with real reach.

Darwin is Australia's tropical northern capital: a compact, friendly harbour city on Larrakia Country, closer to Bali and Singapore than to Sydney. For clinicians it offers breadth and responsibility few places can match, and a life lived outdoors, with sunset markets, waterfalls and some of the world's great wilderness on the doorstep.

~150,000

people across Darwin
and Palmerston

2

seasons that set the
calendar: the Dry and
the Wet

~1 hr 30

by road to the waterfalls
of Litchfield

~2 hr 30

direct flight to Bali

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Why clinicians choose Darwin

02 A tropical harbour city on Larrakia
Country

03 Healthcare in Darwin

04 Where to live in Darwin

05 Getting around Darwin

06 What it costs to live here

07 Sophie's insights

08 Food, markets and the everyday

09 What people do at the weekend

10 Around Darwin and beyond

11 Families and schools in Darwin

12 Local directory

13 Useful contacts

14 Your Ethicare journey

Guides describe places, not employers. Hospitals are described rather than named, and salaries, visas and registration rules change, so we confirm the detail with you directly.

Why clinicians choose Darwin

Darwin offers some of the broadest clinical practice in Australia inside a small, genuinely global city. People often come for a year or two for the experience, and a good number find they never want to leave.



If you're looking for big-city anonymity and four crisp seasons, Darwin may not be it. But if you're drawn to warm evenings, a close-knit community and clinical work with real reach and responsibility, it could be a wonderful choice.

Around 150,000 people live across Darwin and its satellite city, Palmerston, on a harbour that opens onto the Timor Sea. It is the country's smallest and northernmost capital, and one of its most multicultural: generations of Larrakia, Southeast Asian, Greek, Chinese, Filipino, Indian and many other communities have shaped a city that feels international for its size.

For clinicians, the draw is the work. Darwin is home to the Top End's only tertiary hospital, which also hosts Australia's national critical care and trauma response centre, the team that leads the country's clinical response to disasters across the region. Because the city is the referral hub for a vast network of remote clinics and district hospitals, you see a breadth of presentations, from trauma to tropical medicine to remote and Aboriginal health, that most clinicians never meet this early in a career.

The whole of the Northern Territory is also classed as regional for skilled migration, which can open visa pathways the larger capitals don't offer. We'll always confirm the detail for your situation.

WHAT YOU GAIN

Breadth and responsibility

Broad, hands-on scope and early clinical responsibility, in a system built around it.

Life outdoors

Six glorious months of the Dry: markets most evenings, festivals, fishing, camping and swimming holes within easy reach.

A gateway to Asia

Direct flights to Bali and Singapore make a long weekend in Southeast Asia an ordinary thing to do.

A welcoming community

A city used to newcomers, where people make friends quickly because everyone has arrived from somewhere.

GOOD TO KNOW

Two seasons, not four

The Dry is warm and sunny; the Wet is humid and dramatic, with storms, monsoon rain and a cyclone season that locals plan for calmly. Most people come to love one and enjoy the other.

A smaller professional pool

You'll know most of your specialty within a year. Many people find that is the best part.

Distance from family

Long-haul trips home take planning, so it's worth thinking about how often you'd like to travel.

Some complex referrals travel

A few highly specialised services are referred on to Adelaide or Brisbane, and your team will walk you through how that works.

i

Weighing up your options?

People often compare Darwin with Brisbane, for warmth without the monsoon; with tropical north Queensland; and with Perth, the other far-flung capital, for more scale behind them. Darwin usually offers the most clinical breadth and the strongest sense of adventure. We're always happy to talk any of them through.



The Darwin Waterfront: lawns, a netted swimming lagoon and the harbour, a short walk from the city centre



A small, close-knit clinical community where colleagues quickly become friends

A tropical harbour city on Larrakia Country

Darwin sits on a peninsula at the top of the continent, with water on three sides, a two-season year and a history of rebuilding stronger. Here is the geography, the climate and the people in brief.

The city centre sits on a small peninsula between Darwin Harbour and the open water of Beagle Gulf. The northern suburbs spread up the coast towards Casuarina and the airport, and Palmerston, the fast-growing satellite city, lies about twenty-five minutes south-east across the harbour's arms. Beyond that is the rural belt of Howard Springs and Humpty Doo, then the national parks.

It is a young city in more ways than one. Darwin was badly damaged by air raids in 1942 and almost entirely rebuilt after Cyclone Tracy on Christmas Day 1974. Today it has one of the youngest populations of any Australian capital, building standards among the strongest in the country, and a relaxed, outdoor way of life. The Northern Territory doesn't use daylight saving, and there are no toll roads anywhere in the Territory.



Darwin's city centre and waterfront from the air: compact, green and close to the water

The Dry

MAY – SEP

Clear blue skies, low humidity and warm days of around 30–32°C, with pleasantly cooler nights. This is market, festival, camping and waterfall season, and the city lives outdoors.

The Build-up

OCT – NOV

Hotter and steamier, with highs around 33–35°C, building clouds and spectacular lightning. Locals slow the pace, head for the pool and wait for the first storms.

The Wet

DEC – MAR

Monsoon rains, afternoon storms and lush green country, with highs around 31–33°C. Waterfalls thunder, the city turns to cinemas, museums and long lunches, and it's also cyclone season.

The shoulder

APRIL

The rains ease and late 'knock-'em-down' storms flatten the tall grass. Waterfalls are at their fullest and the first dry-season markets reopen at the end of the month.



Worth planning for: the Wet and cyclone season

Cyclone season runs roughly November to April. Darwin's building code is among Australia's strictest, the Bureau of Meteorology gives plenty of warning, and households keep a simple emergency kit ready each year. The UV is strong all year, so hats and sunscreen become second nature.

GARRAMILLA

Larrakia Country

The Larrakia people are the Traditional Custodians of the Darwin region, known in the Larrakia language as Garramilla. Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings and events across the Territory.

GLOBAL FOR ITS SIZE

A multicultural capital

Among the highest shares of overseas-born and First Nations residents of any Australian capital.

NORTHERN SUBURBS

A defence city too

A significant Defence presence shapes community life, and means plenty of other families are new to town too.

WORKING-AGE ARRIVALS

Young and growing

One of the youngest median ages of any capital, and a city used to welcoming newcomers.

Healthcare in Darwin

The Northern Territory runs a public health system built for distance, and Darwin sits at its centre. Clinicians here work at a scale of catchment few have experienced, with real responsibility from the start.

Public hospital services in the Top End are run by the Northern Territory Government. In Darwin that means the Territory's tertiary hospital in the northern suburbs, home to the national critical care and trauma response centre, and a newer hospital serving Palmerston and the fast-growing southern suburbs. Around them sit community health centres, mental health services, Aboriginal community-controlled health organisations and private practice.

Darwin is the referral and evacuation hub for a huge network of remote clinics and district hospitals across the Top End, so much of your complex work arrives from somewhere else, often by air. Aeromedical retrieval is a normal part of the system. A small number of highly specialised services sit outside Darwin's scope, and those patients travel on to Adelaide or Brisbane.



Trauma, tropical medicine and retrieval work arrive in Darwin from right across the Top End

1

**tertiary hospital for the
Top End**

and home to Australia's
national trauma response
centre

Remote

referral network

clinics and district
hospitals across a vast
catchment

Regional

status for skilled migration

across the whole Northern
Territory

CAPABLE GENERALISTS

Broad scope

You'll see trauma, tropical disease and complex
chronic illness, and make more of the decisions
yourself.

A REAL CHANCE TO MAKE A DIFFERENCE

Aboriginal health

Many patients come from remote communities,
and working alongside Aboriginal Health
Practitioners and interpreters is part of the daily
picture.

VISIBILITY

Fast progression

In a smaller service, people step into senior,
education and leadership roles sooner than they
would down south.

ALLOWANCES & HOUSING

Packages worth asking about

Remote and market allowances, salary packaging
and, on some roles, subsidised housing are
common enough to ask about before you compare
offers.

i

Working on Country

More than a quarter of the Territory's people are Aboriginal, and many speak English as a second, third or fourth language. Cultural induction, interpreters and Aboriginal Liaison Officers are part of good care here. Nobody expects you to arrive knowing it all; curiosity and respect are what matter.

What to ask at interview

- ☐ What does the aeromedical retrieval or remote-coverage roster look like for my role?
- ☐ Which cases in my specialty are transferred interstate, and how is that handled day to day?
- ☐ What CPD time and funding is offered, given the distance to other major centres?
- ☐ What peer supervision, telehealth links and orientation are there for clinicians new to the Territory?
- ☐ What do salary packaging, any remote or market allowance, and relocation or housing support add up to?



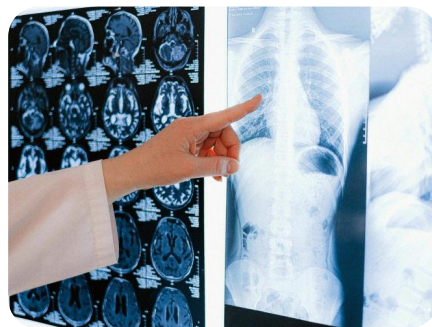
Time with patients and families is at the heart of care in the Top End



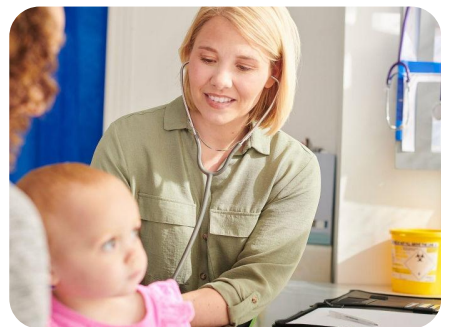
Paediatric and family work is part of a broad Territory caseload



Maternity and neonatal care for families from across the region



Imaging and diagnostics, with telehealth links to colleagues further south



A service where you quickly get to know families and colleagues

Where to live in Darwin

Darwin is compact, so almost nowhere is far from work. The choice comes down to the feel you want: harbourside apartments, leafy family streets by the sea, or a block with room to spread out.



Marina-side homes in Darwin: deep eaves, pale roofs and rooms built to open up to the breeze

~15–20 MIN · HARBOURSIDE

City, Larrakeyah & Cullen Bay

Apartments and townhouses by the water, walkable to the Waterfront, the Esplanade and Mindil Beach. Ideal for singles and couples.

~15 MIN · LIFESTYLE

Fannie Bay & Parap

Leafy, walkable and much loved, close to the museum, the Saturday market, the sailing club and East Point.

~10 MIN · FORESHORE

Nightcliff & Rapid Creek

Relaxed seaside suburbs with a famous foreshore path, Sunday markets and some of the best sunsets in town.

~5–10 MIN · FAMILIES

The northern suburbs

Alawa, Brinkin, Wagaman, Wanguri, Leanyer and neighbours: established family streets close to the tertiary hospital, parks and schools.

NEWER ESTATES

Lyons, Muirhead & Bellamack

Newer homes in planned suburbs, with modern air-conditioning and parks built in. Popular with relocating families.

~25 MIN TO THE CITY · VALUE

Palmerston

Darwin's satellite city, with its own hospital, shopping centre and newer, family-sized homes at good value.

30-40 MIN · ACREAGE

Howard Springs & Humpty Doo

Rural blocks with space for pets, gardens and a boat, a favourite with families who love the outdoor life.

Many Territory health roles, especially anything with a remote component, come with subsidised or provided housing for a period, so confirm what your package includes before you start looking. On the open market, the rental market can move quickly, so many people rent short-term first and choose a suburb once they know the city.

Four things to check before you sign

- ☐ Your work site first: the tertiary hospital in the northern suburbs and the hospital in Palmerston sit in different parts of the city.
- ☐ The school's priority enrolment area, if you have children. Popular schools fill from their local area first.
- ☐ Air-conditioning, ceiling fans, screens and airflow. In the tropics these matter more than square metres.
- ☐ Whether there's a pool, a shaded outdoor area or a common pool nearby. In the Build-up, you'll be glad of it.

Getting around Darwin

Darwin is compact, uncongested and easy to get around. Commutes are short, parking is simple, and the airport is minutes from town, with Asia closer than Sydney.

Most commutes are ten to twenty-five minutes, and there are no toll roads anywhere in the Territory. A car makes daily life simplest, particularly for weekends in the national parks, though many people living close to work manage with one car per household. Australians drive on the left.

The bus network covers Darwin and Palmerston, and the Northern Territory Government has made public buses in Greater Darwin free since July 2025 (check nt.gov.au for the latest). Darwin is flat, with shared paths along the foreshores, so cycling is a real pleasure in the cooler months of the Dry.

JOURNEY	TYPICAL TIME
Northern suburbs → tertiary hospital	5–10 min
City centre → northern suburbs	15–20 min
Nightcliff → city centre	15 min
City centre → airport	~15 min
Palmerston → city centre	~25 min
Howard Springs → city centre	~30–35 min
Humpty Doo → city centre	~40 min

CURRENTLY FREE

Buses

Routes across Darwin, Palmerston and the northern suburbs, with timetables and a journey planner on nt.gov.au.

~15 MIN FROM THE CITY

The airport

Direct flights to every mainland capital, and to Bali and Singapore for onward connections across Asia and to Europe.

PLAN AHEAD

Driving further

Outside the city, distances are large. Carry water, check road conditions (especially in the Wet) and tell someone your plans.

DIRECT FROM DARWIN	ROUGHLY	GOOD FOR
Dili, Timor-Leste	~1 hr 10	Closer than any Australian capital
Bali	~2 hr 30	A genuine long weekend away
Singapore	~4 hr 30	Asia, and onward flights to the UK and Europe
Sydney	~4 hr 30	The same journey as Singapore, which surprises most new arrivals



Sophie's tip

You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for a period after arriving, but once you're a resident you'll need to switch to an NT licence through the Motor Vehicle Registry. Check the current rules for your licence on nt.gov.au.

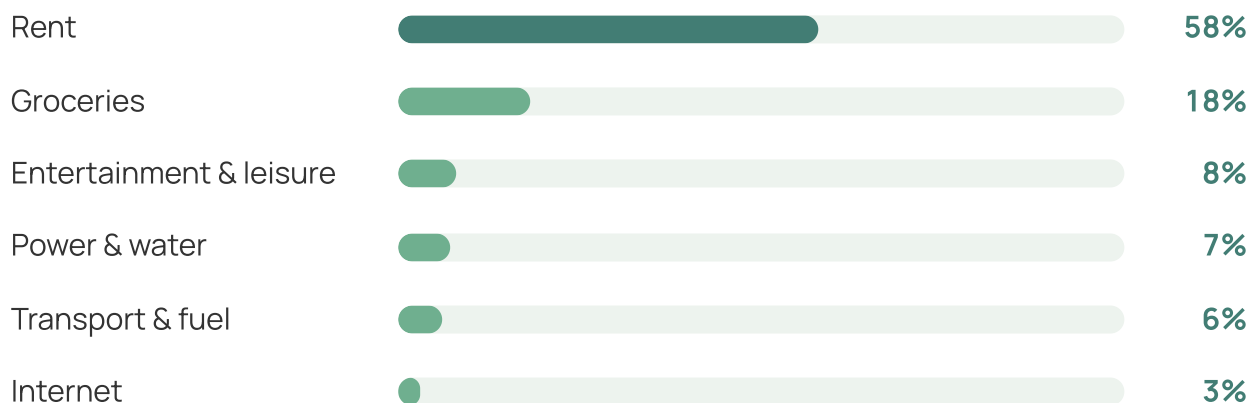
What it costs to live here

Darwin's costs have their own shape: some everyday items cost a little more because they travel a long way to get here, while allowances, short commutes, free buses and no tolls often more than balance the picture.

We don't print rents or prices, because they date quickly. What doesn't date is the shape of a month, and which lines are worth planning for. For today's numbers, use the calculators in the directory at the back of this guide, and compare Darwin with the city you're leaving.

Groceries and household goods tend to cost a little more than in the southern capitals, because so much is freighted a long way. Your power bill peaks in the Build-up and the Wet, when the air-conditioning works hardest, rather than in winter. On the other side of the ledger, Territory packages often include remote or market allowances, salary packaging and sometimes housing support, which is why it pays to look at the whole offer rather than a headline figure.

Where a month goes



Proportions for one person on a mid-range budget, not amounts. Rent is the biggest line; in Darwin the power bill is a wet-season story rather than a winter one.

The costs worth planning for

- ✓ Cooling. A well-insulated home with efficient air-conditioning and fans is worth a little more rent.
- ✓ Groceries. Markets, seasonal tropical produce and bulk buys keep the weekly shop sensible; keep a cooler bag in the car.
- ✓ Getting home. Long-haul flights usually connect through Singapore or a southern capital, so build trips home into your plans.
- ✓ Weekends and holidays. Camping gear, a fishing rod and the odd Bali getaway tend to find their way into the budget.



The Wave Lagoon at the Darwin Waterfront: one of the city's year-round places to swim, and a favourite with families

IN SHORT

- ✓ On a clinical salary, with Territory allowances, most people live comfortably and have plenty left for travel and weekends.
- ✓ Ask what your package includes (allowances, packaging, relocation and housing) before comparing offers.
- ✓ Choose a cool, well-ventilated home; it pays for itself in comfort and power bills.



SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

What I tell people about Darwin

What strikes me most about Darwin is how quickly it becomes home. It's a city that asks you to say yes: to the heat, to a smaller community, to a rhythm built around the Dry and the Wet. Having supported clinicians moving to the Top End, I've watched people arrive for 'a year or two' and then find, years later, that they can't imagine leaving.

The clinical breadth is something very few places in Australia can offer, and the life around it is just as special: sunset markets, waterfalls on a Saturday, friends from every corner of the world, and Bali a short flight away. My one piece of advice is to give yourself a full year, and live through a wet season before you decide. For the right person, Darwin is an adventure that turns into a home.

Sophie Careem

Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing



Shared tables and new friendships: Darwin is a city where people make friends quickly



A slow coffee before a market morning

Food, markets and the everyday

Food is one of Darwin's great joys: a multicultural, Southeast-Asian-influenced city where the markets are as much a social life as a place to eat.

THU & SUN EVENINGS · LATE APR-OCT

Mindil Beach Sunset Market

Food stalls from across Asia and beyond, craft, live music and a sunset over the water that half the city turns out for.

SATURDAY MORNINGS

Parap Village Market

Darwin's much-loved weekly market, locally famous for its laksa, tropical fruit and coffee.

WEEKEND MORNINGS, YEAR-ROUND

Rapid Creek Market

An Asian-style produce market: dragon fruit, durian, Asian greens, fresh seafood and street food.

SUNDAY MORNINGS

Nightcliff Market

A relaxed foreshore market with breakfast, coffee, music and the neighbourhood out in force.



Laksa, curries and noodles: Southeast Asian flavours are everyday food in Darwin



Indian and Sri Lankan food is easy to find, with spices and staples at local grocers

Woolworths and Coles cover the weekly shop across the city, with IGA and independent grocers filling the gaps. Darwin's Asian and multicultural grocers are a real strength, and halal, Southeast Asian, Indian and Chinese staples are easy to find. Single-use plastic bags are banned across the Territory, so keep a few reusable ones in the car.

Barramundi is the fish everyone has an opinion about, whether catching it or cooking it, and fishing is close to a Territory religion. Eating out leans casual and outdoors: waterfront cafés, sailing-club sunsets and plenty of good-value Thai, Vietnamese, Indonesian, Greek and Indian kitchens.

Words you'll hear in your first week

- ✓ **The Dry / the Wet:** the two seasons that replace four here.
- ✓ **Territorian:** anyone who calls the NT home, however recently they arrived.
- ✓ **Crocwise:** knowing where it's safe to swim, and where it isn't.
- ✓ **The Build-up:** the hot, humid weeks before the Wet properly arrives.
- ✓ **Top End:** the tropical north of the Territory, as distinct from 'the Centre' around Alice Springs.

i

The rhythm of the year

In the Dry, life runs outdoors: markets most evenings, the Darwin Festival in August, open-air cinema and sport every weekend. In the Wet, the rhythm turns inward and slower, with afternoon storms, museums, cafés and friends' pools. Both seasons have their fans.



Café brunch is a weekend ritual, especially on cooler Dry-season mornings



Breakfast out before the heat of the day



Japanese, Thai, Vietnamese and more: the city eats across Asia

What people do at the weekend

A Darwin weekend in the Dry might be a market breakfast, a dip under a waterfall, an evening at the beach and a camp under the stars. In the Wet, it slows down beautifully.

Closer to home, East Point Reserve and the Nightcliff foreshore put nature inside the city: wallabies at dusk, a long coastal path for walking and cycling, and some of the best sunsets in Australia. The George Brown Darwin Botanic Gardens, the Museum and Art Gallery of the Northern Territory at Fannie Bay and the Deckchair Cinema by the harbour are local favourites.

Further out, the national parks are what make a Top End weekend: waterfalls and swimming holes at Litchfield, an easy day trip, and the wetlands and ancient rock art of Kakadu for a long weekend.

A typical Darwin weekend in the Dry

- ✓ Saturday breakfast and a laksa at Parap, or Sunday morning at Nightcliff or Rapid Creek.
- ✓ A day trip to Litchfield for the waterfalls and swimming holes, back by dinner.
- ✓ A fishing trip on the harbour, or camping at Berry Springs or further afield.
- ✓ A walk or ride along the Nightcliff foreshore or around East Point, looking out for wallabies.
- ✓ Sunset at Mindil Beach with dinner from the market stalls.
- ✓ In the Wet: the Waterfront lagoons, the museum, cinemas and long lunches while the storms roll in.



Rock art in Kakadu, around two and a half to three hours from Darwin: some of the oldest continuing art traditions on earth

~10 MIN

East Point Reserve

Bushland, wallabies, WWII history and a coastal loop with sunset views over the water.

~45 MIN

Berry Springs

Shady springs for a Dry-season swim and the Territory Wildlife Park next door.

~1 HR 30

Litchfield National Park

Waterfalls, plunge pools and giant termite mounds; the classic Top End day trip.

~2 HR 30-3 HRS

Kakadu National Park

World Heritage wetlands, birdlife, gorges and rock art. Best as a long weekend.

i

Good to know: swimming safely

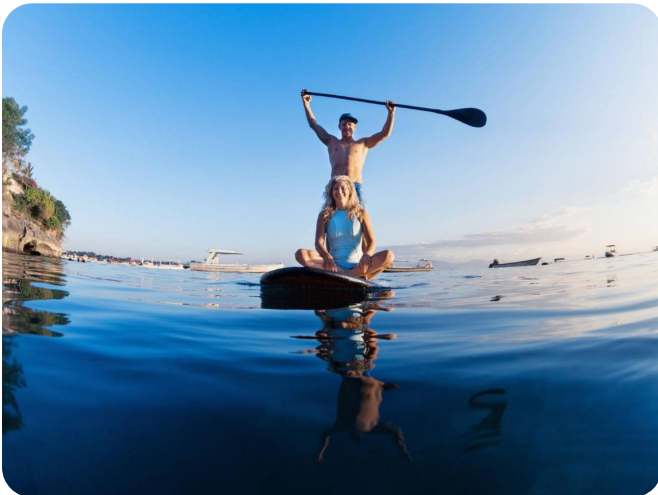
Swimming is a big part of Top End life, done the local way. Saltwater crocodiles live in the sea, rivers and many waterholes, so only swim in signed, managed swimming spots and follow the NT Government's Be Crocwise advice. Box jellyfish and other stingers are mostly found in the sea from around October to May, so locals swim at the Waterfront's netted lagoons, pools and approved waterholes instead. Check signs and park alerts before every trip; some sites close in the Wet.



Camping is a Dry-season ritual, with campgrounds across the national parks



Wildlife is part of everyday life in the Territory, from wallabies at East Point to kangaroos further inland



Paddling on calm water: check local croc and stinger advice first



Market breakfasts and tropical fruit start many a Darwin weekend



Tropical reefs, for a snorkelling holiday a short flight away



Uluru, in the Red Centre: worth a trip of its own in the cooler months

Around Darwin and beyond

Darwin's greatest weekend advantage is what lies within a few hours of it: World Heritage wilderness, gorges, island culture, the Red Centre and, a short flight away, all of Southeast Asia.

Litchfield, ninety minutes south, is the easy day trip: waterfalls, clear plunge pools and walking tracks. Kakadu, Australia's largest national park, is a long weekend of wetlands, billabong cruises, escarpments and rock-art galleries. Further south, Nitmiluk (Katherine Gorge) is a series of sandstone gorges you can cruise, canoe or walk above, and nearby hot springs make a lovely stop. These are Dry-season trips; in the Wet some roads and swimming spots close, though the falls are at their most spectacular from the air.

The Tiwi Islands, just north of Darwin, are known for their distinctive art and culture and are usually visited on a guided day tour. The Red Centre, with Uluru, Kata Tjuta and Alice Springs, is in the same Territory but a trip of its own, best planned as a holiday. And because Darwin is Australia's door to Asia, Bali, Singapore and beyond are often closer than a trip south.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Mindil, Casuarina & the Waterfront	5–20 min	The nearest beaches, for sunsets, picnics and walks. For a swim, locals use the Waterfront's netted lagoons, pools and managed swimming spots.
Darwin International Airport	~15 min	Direct flights to every mainland capital, Bali and Singapore.
Litchfield National Park	~1 hr 30	Waterfalls, plunge pools and walks; the classic Dry-season day trip.
Kakadu National Park	~2 hr 30–3 hrs	World Heritage wetlands, wildlife and ancient rock art.
Katherine & Nitmiluk Gorge	~3–3 hr 30	The nearest town of any size, and a dramatic gorge system to cruise or paddle.
Alice Springs & the Red Centre	~2 hr flight	Uluru, Kata Tjuta and the desert ranges: a holiday rather than a weekend.
Other capital cities	~3 hr 30–4 hr 30 flight	Brisbane, Adelaide, Perth, Sydney and Melbourne are all direct flights.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
The nearest ski fields	a flight south	The snow is a long way from the tropics: fly to Melbourne or Sydney for the Victorian Alps or the Snowy Mountains, and make it a winter holiday to remember.
Bali & Southeast Asia	~2 hr 30 flight	Long weekends in Bali, and Singapore as a gateway across Asia.

~1 HR 30

Litchfield

Florence Falls, Wangi Falls and Buley Rockhole: swimming spots surrounded by monsoon forest (check which are open).

~2 HR 30–3 HRS

Kakadu

Wetlands full of birdlife, a cruise on Yellow Water, and rock-art galleries painted over tens of thousands of years.

~3 HR 30

Nitmiluk (Katherine Gorge)

Thirteen gorges carved into sandstone. Cruise, canoe or walk, and soak in the Katherine Hot Springs.

SHORT FLIGHT OR TOUR

The Tiwi Islands

Island communities famous for their art, carving and love of Aussie Rules football.

~45 MIN

Berry Springs

Swimming in the Dry and the Territory Wildlife Park, a family favourite.

~2 HR 30–4 HR 30

Bali & Singapore

A long weekend in Asia is an ordinary Darwin holiday, and many families make it a yearly ritual.



Uluru, in the Red Centre: a flight from Darwin, and a journey most Territorians make at least once



Kata Tjuta, near Uluru in Central Australia



Alice Springs and the MacDonnell Ranges, the heart of the Red Centre



With Southeast Asia so close, a snorkelling holiday in tropical waters is easy to plan



Tropical reef life, a short flight away across the region



Coral and reef fish: diving and snorkelling holidays are within easy flying reach



A turtle over a tropical reef, the kind of encounter that makes a holiday

Families and schools in Darwin

Darwin is a wonderful place to raise children who love the outdoors: short commutes, free water parks, sport for every age, and a community where families from everywhere quickly make friends.



Outdoor play, mud kitchens and plenty of shade: early learning in the tropics



Art, play and plenty of outdoor time are at the heart of early learning

Schooling in the Northern Territory runs in stages: an optional preschool year, then Transition (the first year of school), primary years to Year 6, middle years from Year 7 to 9, and senior years from Year 10 to 12, leading to the Northern Territory Certificate of Education and Training (NTCET). School is compulsory from age six, and the year runs across four terms.

Most children attend government schools. Alongside them are Catholic schools run through Catholic Education NT and a range of independent and Christian schools. Government schools give priority to children living in their priority enrolment area, so check the area for any school you have in mind before you sign a lease. Long-established options include Darwin High School and Casuarina Senior College in the government sector, St John's Catholic College, and the independent Kormilda College and Haileybury Rendall School.

i

Good news on school fees

The NT Government does not charge international student fees at government schools for the dependants of temporary skilled visa holders, including subclasses 482, 491 and 494. Other visa types may differ, so check the 'School fees for international students' page on nt.gov.au for your visa.

What children tend to love here

- ✓ Leanyer Recreation Park, a free water park with slides and splash pools in the northern suburbs.
- ✓ The Territory Wildlife Park at Berry Springs, and wallabies at East Point.
- ✓ Club sport for every age: Aussie Rules football, netball, soccer, cricket, swimming, sailing and fishing.
- ✓ The Waterfront's Wave Lagoon and netted Recreation Lagoon, for safe swimming all year.
- ✓ The Museum and Art Gallery of the NT, including its Cyclone Tracy gallery and a famous saltwater crocodile.
- ✓ Sunset picnics at Mindil Beach on market nights.

Choosing a school

- ☐ Check the priority enrolment area for the exact address before you sign a lease.
- ☐ Look at school profiles on the My School website and the list of urban schools on nt.gov.au.
- ☐ Visit, or ask for a video call. Principals in Darwin are used to families arriving from overseas and interstate.
- ☐ Ask how the school supports children new to Australia, including English as an additional language.
- ☐ Ask where to buy the uniform; most schools sell it through their own uniform shop or a local supplier.



Early childhood

The year before Transition is preschool, offered through the government school system and by other providers, and childcare centres and family day care are found across the city. Check eligibility for the Australian Government's Child Care Subsidy, which depends on your visa.

CASUARINA CAMPUS · UNIVERSITY & TAFE

Charles Darwin University

A dual-sector university offering degrees and vocational training, including nursing, allied health and paramedicine, alongside TAFE courses.

JOIN A CLUB

Sport and community

Joining a club is the fastest way into Darwin life, for parents as much as for children.



After the bell: afternoons in Darwin often end at the pool or the park



Senior years lead to the Northern Territory Certificate of Education and Training



Registering the family with a local GP is one of the first jobs after arriving



Medicare and community health services cover families once you're eligible



Short commutes leave more time for family at the end of a shift

“

Come for the adventure; stay for the people, the sunsets and the work that really matters.

Your Darwin address book

Darwin is one of Australia's most multicultural cities for its size, with long-established Filipino, Greek, Indian, Sri Lankan and Southeast Asian communities and a Malayalee association that has been bringing Kerala families together since 2008. The NT Government's own multicultural directory lists well over a hundred community groups, and the Multicultural Council of the NT helps newcomers find their way in.

COUNCILS & LOCAL SERVICES

City of Darwin

Rubbish and recycling, libraries, pools, parks, Leanyer Recreation Park and city events

darwin.nt.gov.au

City of Palmerston

Council services for Palmerston and its suburbs

08 8935 9922 palmerston.nt.gov.au

Litchfield Council

The rural area around Howard Springs and Humpty Doo

08 8983 0600 litchfield.nt.gov.au

NT Government: public buses

Darwin and Palmerston bus timetables, maps and the journey planner

nt.gov.au

healthdirect

Free 24-hour health advice line, staffed by registered nurses

1800 022 222 healthdirect.gov.au

Bureau of Meteorology

Forecasts, wet-season storm and cyclone warnings for the Top End

bom.gov.au

GETTING TO KNOW THE PLACE

Tourism NT

The Territory's official visitor site: events, national parks and things to do

northernterritory.com

Mindil Beach Sunset Market

Market nights, dates and stallholders through the Dry

mindil.com.au

Charles Darwin University

University and TAFE courses, public events and the Casuarina campus

cdu.edu.au

COMMUNITY & CULTURAL ASSOCIATIONS

Multicultural Council of the NT (MCNT)

Peak body for multicultural communities in the Territory: settlement support for recent arrivals, a homework club, emergency relief and community events. Shop 15, Malak Shopping Centre.

08 8945 9122 mcnt.org.au

NT Government multicultural organisations directory

The Office of Multicultural Affairs' list of community associations across Darwin and the Territory, by community.

nt.gov.au/community/multicultural-communities

Darwin Malayalee Association (DMA)

Not-for-profit Malayali community organisation started in 2008 by Malayalam-speaking Darwin residents; festivals, events and membership.

darwinmalayale.com.au

Darwin Malayalee Forum

A second Malayali community group, listed in the NT Government multicultural directory.

Tatvamasi (Foundation of Hindu Malayalees NT)

Hindu Malayali cultural group, listed in the NT Government multicultural directory.

Indian Cultural Society of NT (ICSNT)

Indian cultural association: Deepavali, cultural workshops, performances and community gatherings.
icsdarwin.com

Filipino-Australian Association of the NT (FAANT)

Darwin's Filipino community association since 1997; culture, community and heritage events.
faant.org.au

Sri Lanka-Australia Friendship Association

Sri Lankan community group, listed in the NT Government multicultural directory.

Tamil Society of the NT

Tamil community group, listed in the NT Government multicultural directory.

Zimbabwe Darwin Community

Zimbabwean community group, listed in the NT Government multicultural directory.

Africa-Australia Friendship Association

African community group, listed in the NT Government multicultural directory.

Northern Territory Irish Association

'The go-to place for all things Irish in the Territory': social events and connections for Irish people in the NT.
ntirish.org.au

Greek Orthodox Community of North Australia

Representative body of Darwin's long-established Greek community since 1969: St Nicholas church, Greek language school and cultural events. 92 Cavenagh Street.
gocna.com.au

Melaleuca Australia

Darwin settlement organisation for refugees and migrants: settlement, counselling and family services. 24 McLachlan Street.
08 8985 3311 melaleuca.org.au

Adult Migrant English Program (AMEP)

Free English classes for eligible migrants, including some provisional and permanent visa holders and their families; check eligibility for your visa.
dewr.gov.au/adult-migrant-english-program

PLACES OF WORSHIP

St Mary's Star of the Sea Cathedral (Catholic)

The Catholic cathedral of the Diocese of Darwin. 90 Smith Street, Darwin City.
darwin.catholic.org.au

Christ Church Cathedral (Anglican)

Anglican cathedral in the city centre; Sunday services morning and evening. 2 Smith Street.
christchurchcathedral.com.au

C3 Church Darwin (Pentecostal)

Pentecostal church in Malak, with a city service and a Palmerston location.
c3darwin.com.au

St Nicholas Greek Orthodox Church

Run by the Greek Orthodox Community of North Australia. Cavenagh Street.
gocna.com.au

Islamic Society of Darwin

Runs the Darwin Mosque and Islamic Centre in Wanguri; prayer times and community programmes.
isodnt.org.au

Islamic Society of Palmerston

Muslim community in Palmerston, with a prayer hall and a new Islamic Centre being built.
isp.org.au

Hindu Society of the NT

Hindu temple and Harmony Hall in Malak; festivals and community events.
hsnt.org.au

Sikh Association of the NT

Sikh community association and gurdwara for Darwin.
santi.org.au

Darwin International Buddhist Temple

Buddhist temple and society established in 1983. 37 Parkside Crescent, Leanyer.
ntbuddhist.com.au

HALAL, KOSHER & INTERNATIONAL GROCERIES

Rapid Creek Markets

Darwin's Asian-style produce market every Saturday and Sunday, 7am to 2pm, year-round: tropical fruit, Asian vegetables, fresh seafood and meat.
rapidcreekmarkets.com.au

SUPERMARKETS & MARKETS

Woolworths

Supermarkets across Darwin, the northern suburbs and Palmerston.
woolworths.com.au

Coles

Supermarkets across Darwin, the northern suburbs and Palmerston.
coles.com.au

Mindil Beach Sunset Market

Thursdays and Sundays, 4pm to 9pm, from the last Thursday of April to the last Thursday of October: more than 150 food and craft stalls by the beach.
mindil.com.au

Nightcliff Markets

Sunday-morning foreshore market with food, coffee, entertainment and shopping.
nightcliffmarkets.com.au

Casuarina Square

Darwin's largest shopping centre, in the northern suburbs. 247 Trower Road, Casuarina.
casuarinasquare.com.au

SCHOOLS & UNIFORMS

NT Government: list of urban and remote schools

Every Territory school, with contact details; also enrolment, stages of schooling and term dates.
nt.gov.au/learning/primary-and-secondary-students/list-of-urban-and-remote-schools

NT Government: school fees for international students

Which visa holders pay fees at NT government schools (dependants of 482, 491 and 494 visa holders do not).
nt.gov.au/learning/international-education/study-at-an-nt-government-school/school-fees-for-international-students

Catholic Education NT

Catholic schools across Darwin and the Territory, with a find-a-school directory.
08 8984 1400 ceont.catholic.edu.au

NT Government: school uniforms

Uniforms are required at government schools from Transition to Year 12; each school sets its own and tells parents where to buy it.
nt.gov.au/learning/primary-and-secondary-students/school-uniforms

My School

Profiles of every Australian school.
myschool.edu.au

HOUSING & AREAS

realestate.com.au

Rental and sale listings across Darwin, Palmerston and the rural area.
realestate.com.au

Domain

Rental and sale listings.
domain.com.au

Flatmates.com.au

Rooms and house shares, handy for a first few months.
flatmates.com.au

NT Government: security deposits (bonds)

In the NT your bond (up to 4 weeks' rent) is held in trust by the landlord or agent rather than a central bond authority; your rights and how to get it back.

nt.gov.au/property/private-renters/find-out-about-rental-costs/security-deposits-bonds

Darwin Community Legal Service: Tenants' Advice

Free advice for renters on leases, repairs, bonds and disputes.

dcls.org.au/tenants-advice

GETTING AROUND

NT Government: Darwin and Palmerston buses

Timetables, maps and the online journey planner. Public buses in Greater Darwin have been free since 1 July 2025.

nt.gov.au/driving/public-transport-cycling

Motor Vehicle Registry (MVR), NT Government

Driver licences, including switching an overseas or interstate licence to an NT licence, and vehicle registration.

nt.gov.au/driving

Darwin International Airport

Flights, parking and getting to and from the airport.

darwinairport.com.au

COST COMPARISON LINKS

Numbeo: Darwin

Crowd-sourced cost-of-living comparison; compare Darwin with the city you're leaving.

numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Darwin

Expatistan

A second cost-of-living comparison, worth running as a cross-check.

expatistan.com/cost-of-living/darwin

Australian Bureau of Statistics

Official price and household statistics, including the Darwin consumer price index.

abs.gov.au



Checked October 2026

Community groups, shops and pages change. If a link has moved or you know a group we should add, tell us and we will update the guide.

Numbers and websites to keep handy

The national services every newcomer uses, wherever in Australia you land.

EMERGENCIES & HEALTH ADVICE

Emergency services

Police, fire and ambulance, any time
000

Emergency from a mobile

Also connects to emergency services from any mobile phone
112

healthdirect

Free 24/7 health advice from a registered nurse
1800 022 222 [healthdirect.gov.au](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au)

Lifeline

24/7 crisis support and suicide prevention, by phone, text or chat
13 11 14 [lifeline.org.au](https://www.lifeline.org.au)

Poisons Information Centre

24/7 advice if someone may have been poisoned
13 11 26

Pregnancy, Birth and Baby

Free support for parents from pregnancy to preschool
1800 882 436 [pregnancybirthbaby.org.au](https://www.pregnancybirthbaby.org.au)

Private health insurance complaints

The Commonwealth Ombudsman's free complaints service
1300 737 299 [ombudsman.gov.au](https://www.ombudsman.gov.au)

VISAS, REGISTRATION & WORK

Department of Home Affairs

Visas, skilled occupation lists and processing times
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au

ImmiAccount

Lodge and track your visa application online
online.immi.gov.au

Register of migration agents (OMARA)

Check an agent is registered before you pay
mara.gov.au

Ahpra

National registration and the National Boards
1300 419 495 ahpra.gov.au

Fair Work Ombudsman

Awards, pay rates and your rights at work
13 13 94 [fairwork.gov.au](https://www.fairwork.gov.au)

HEALTHCARE FOR YOUR FAMILY

Medicare · Services Australia

Enrolment, cards, claims and reciprocal health care agreements
132 011 [servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare](https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare)

healthdirect service finder

Find a GP, pharmacy, urgent care or hospital near you
[healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services)

privatehealth.gov.au

Compare private health cover independently; run by the Commonwealth Ombudsman
[privatehealth.gov.au](https://www.privatehealth.gov.au)

SCHOOLS & CHILDCARE

NSW school finder

Government schools and catchments in New South Wales
[education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder](https://www.education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder)

Find my school (Victoria)

School zones for any Victorian address
[findmyschool.vic.gov.au](https://www.findmyschool.vic.gov.au)

Find a school (Queensland)

State schools and catchment areas
qld.gov.au/education/schools/find

Find a public school (WA)

Western Australian public schools and local-intake areas
wa.gov.au/service/education-and-training/school-education/find-public-school

School zones (South Australia)

Zone maps for government schools
education.sa.gov.au/parents-and-families/enrol-school-or-preschool/zones-catchments-and-capacity-management/maps-school-zones-enrolment-year

Find your local school (Tasmania)

Intake areas for Tasmanian government schools
decyp.tas.gov.au/learning/find-your-local-school

Priority enrolment areas (ACT)

Find a Canberra public school for your address
act.gov.au/education-and-training/find-a-school-and-enrol

Choose a school (NT)

Urban and remote schools in the Northern Territory
nt.gov.au/learning/primary-and-secondary-students/choose-a-school

Starting Blocks

Compare childcare services and quality ratings near you
startingblocks.gov.au

Child Care Subsidy

Eligibility, rates and how to apply
servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy

MONEY & HOME

Australian Taxation Office

Apply for your tax file number (TFN), tax and super
13 28 61 ato.gov.au

Moneysmart

Free, independent budgeting, super and banking tools
moneysmart.gov.au

SETTLING IN

TIS National

Free interpreting by phone, 24/7, in 150+ languages
131 450 tisnational.gov.au

Settle in Australia

Home Affairs' settlement topics and services for new arrivals
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia

MyAus app

Government app to help newcomers find services, in many languages
myausapp.com

Overseas drivers (Austroads)

How overseas licences are recognised, with links to each state's licensing authority
austroads.gov.au/drivers-and-vehicles/overseas-drivers/country-recognition

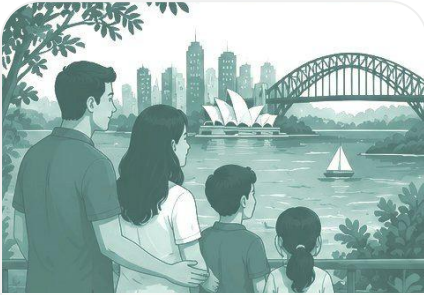


Always check the source

Rules, fees and services change. Treat these as starting points and confirm details with the organisation. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not registered migration agents.

Six steps, and someone beside you for each one

Moving country is a sequence of decisions. We take them with you in order, so you are never solving step five before step two is done.



STEP 1

Discovery call

A relaxed conversation about your profession, your family and what you want from a move. No forms, no pressure.



STEP 2

Eligibility & registration

We map your route to Ahpra registration and help you gather the evidence the regulator will ask for.



STEP 3

Opportunities & interviews

Roles matched to where you want to live and how you like to work, with honest briefings before every interview.



STEP 4

Offer & decision support

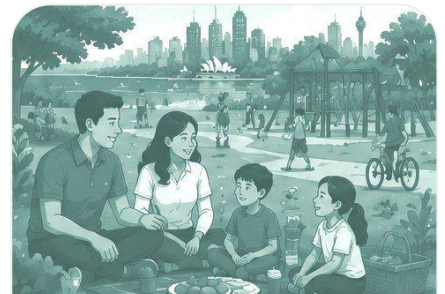
We help you read the offer properly: pay step, relocation support, roster and what the team is really like.



STEP 5

Visa & relocation guidance

Practical guidance on visas, shipping, pets, schools and the first weeks, so nothing arrives as a surprise.



STEP 6

Settling in

We stay in touch after you land, from your first week on the ward to your first winter.



— READY TO EXPLORE OPPORTUNITIES?

Picture yourself in Darwin. Then let's make it real.

Tell us what you do and where you would like to live. We will come back with roles that fit, a clear view of the registration route, and time to answer every question.



Ethicare Resourcing

hello@ethicareresourcing.com · +44 7375 019544 · ethicareresourcing.com

One Coldbath Square, London EC1R 5HL · Company No. 14646354